# Fat Skinny Joke

## By Rachel Wiley and Blythe Baird

## INTRODUCTION

*"Health" is something we focus on a lot in today's society. Fat burning supplements, new diets, exercise programs, eating "clean" — we designate certain things as "healthy," which makes them desirable.*

*Fat??? = non-desirable. But is being overweight always a conscious choice to be non-healthy? When it comes to weight, multiple factors are at play, many of which are beyond a person's control: genetics, childhood habits, medical conditions, and hormones.*

*This collection, Fat/Skinny Joke by Rachel Wiley and Blythe Baird explores two ends of the body image spectrum. Obesity and anorexia.*

## Fat Joke

**(Pg 22-23)** The old joke goes:

Patient walks into the doctor's office and says, "Doctor it hurts when

I move my arm like this, what should I do?" and the doctor says, "So don't move your arm like that."

Now,

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Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office and says, "Doctor, it hurts

when I move my arm like this, what should I do?" and the doctor

says, "Have you considered weight loss surgery?"

Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office for a flue shot

and gets a lecture about BMI

Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office for an earache and gets asked if

she's ever eaten a salad

Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office with a spider bit and the

doctor obsesses over how low her blood pressure is – low for such a

fat person anyway – and insists on checking it 3 times before he

believes it, has to be reminded of the purple mass of throbbing spider

venom that brought her here in the first place

Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office to ask about antidepressants

and gets prescribed exercise instead

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Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office for a standard 3-
month followup
appointment and the doctor says, "Have you considered
weight
Loss surgery?"
Fat Girl gets tired of only ever being diagnosed fat
so Fat Girl stops walking into the doctor's office
Fat Girl walks to the store
and has insults flicked at her like still-lit
cigarettes from passing cars
Fat Girl walks onto a crowded bus and stands because she
does not
wish to share a seat and make anyone else uncomfortable
Fat Girl logs onto the internet, gets comments from
keyboard doctors
that claim concern for her health
suggests crash diets
suggests flat-tummy tea
Suggests diet pills that would stop fat girl's heart but fat girl
will have
died trying to get thin
Fat Girl walks into the world and says,

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"World, it hurts to exist like this."
World says, "So stop existing like that"
World says, "Have you considered weight loss surgery?"
would rather she slice herself open than to exist as she
does
side-effects be damned
Despite all of this, Fat Girl still manages to love her fat body
World says, "Stop glorifying obesity."
Fat Girl walks up to World, says, "I do not owe you
shrinking, you
know. I do not owe you thinness, attempted thinness, or
desired
thinness because you assume thinness equals health. I do
not owe you
health, perceived or otherwise, to receive basic respect. I
am
deserving of existence. I am deserving of care. I am
deserving of first
no harm done."
World says,
"That is the best joke we've heard all day."

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Rachel Wiley***
***Book: Nothing is Okay***
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***Publisher: Button Poetry***
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*But it's a joke that is decidedly un-funny. You hear "anorexia" and you think bone-thin young women -- scary-skinny runway models with emaciated figures. But according to Dr. Leslie A. Sim, clinical director of the Mayo Clinic's eating disorders program, people with a history of obesity are at "significant risk" for developing anorexia.*

*When the Fat Girl Gest Skinny by Blythe Baird*

## When the Fat Girl Gets Skinny

**(Pg 3-6)** the year of skinny pop and sugar-free jello cups
we guzzled vitamin water and vodka

toasting to high school and survival
complimenting each other's collarbones
trying diets we found on the internet:
menthol cigarettes, eating in front of a mirror,
donating blood.

replacing meals with other practical hobbies
like making flower crowns
or fainting
wondering why I haven't had my period
in months

why breakfast tastes like
giving up
or how many more productive ways
I could have spent my time today
besides googling the calories
in the glue of a US envelope
watching America's Next Top Model
like the gospel,
hunching naked over a bathroom scale shrine,
crying into an empty bowl of Cocoa Puffs
because I only feel pretty
when I'm hungry
if you are not recovering,
you are dying.
by the time I was sixteen, I had already experienced being
clinically overweight, underweight, and obese.

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as a child, fat was the first word
people used to describe me,
which didn't offend me until
I found out it was supposed to.
when I lost weight, my dad was so proud
he started carrying my before-and-after photo
in his wallet.
so relieved he could stop worrying
about me getting diabetes.
he saw a program on the news
about the epidemic with obesity
says he is just so glad to finally see me
taking care of myself.
if you develop an eating disorder
when you are already thin to begin with,
you go to the hospital.
if you develop an eating disorder
when you are not thin to begin with,
you are a success story.
so when I evaporated, of course
everyone congratulated me
on getting healthy.

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girls at school who never spoke to me before
stopped me in the hallway to ask how I did it.
I say, I am sick.
They say No, you are

an inspiration.
How could I not fall
in love with my illness?
With becoming the kind of silhouette
people are supposed to fall in love with?
why would I ever want to stop
being hungry
when anorexia was the most
interesting thing about me?
so, how lucky it is, now,
to be boring
the way not going to the hospital
is boring.
the way looking at an apple
and seeing only an apple, not sixty

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or half an hour of sit-ups
is boring.
My story may not be as exciting as it used
to be, but at least there is nothing left
to count.
the calculator in my head
finally stopped.
I used to love the feeling of drinking water
on an empty stomach
waiting for the coolness to slip all
the way down and land in the well
not obsessed with being empty
but afraid of being full.
I used to take pride in being able to feel
cold in a warm room.
now, I am proud I have stopped
seeking revenge on this body.
this was the year of eating
when I was hungry

without punishing myself

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and I know it sounds ridiculous,
but that shit is hard.
when I was little,
someone asked me

what I wanted to be
when I grew up,

and I said

small

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Blythe Baird***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2020 National Qualifier – MS – as a Collection***
***2024 National Qualifier – MS – Fat Joke by R. Wiley only***

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